

HONING OUR DEFENCES

For nearly six decades now, **DRDO has helped the country fulfil its mission of self-reliance** and improve its indigenous defence capabilities

By ***Pradip R. Sagar***

The seeds of defence R&D in India were sown by eminent theoretical physicist D.S. Kothari, also our first scientific advisor. The Defence Service Organisation he founded in 1948 was to become the DRDO (Defence Research and Development Organisation) in 10 years, in association with several technical development establishments. From a primarily advisory role in operations research, ballistics, weapons evaluation, physiology, food and nutrition for the armed forces, the new organisation was tasked with the design and development of equipment based on operational requirements of the triservices, applied research and technical evaluation trials of weapons.

So, if in the 1970s, the DRDO contributed to a peaceful nuclear explosion, 51 mm mortar, surface-to-air missile, 105 mm field gun, secondary surveillance radar and the Indra radar, the '80s were an era of evolution of missiles, tanks and combat aircraft. By the